

Key terms + ideas

- the state
- regime
- government
- comparative method
- hypothesis
- structuralist
- voluntarist
- correlation vs. causation

Key questions

Q: Why do we study comparative politics (CP)?

A: We study comparative politics to describe and explain as Lasswell encapsulates “who gets what, when and how” (Samuels 2013, p. 4) in different places around the world. And because it’s fun!

Q: What is the comparative method? What are its goals?

A: The comparative method seeks to compare and contrast cases that are similar with different outcomes or cases that are different with the same outcome. Its goal is to generate hypotheses that explain the essential task of comparative politics.

Q: What are independent and dependent variables?

A: Independent variables are explanatory factors, or the means by which you attempt to explain a phenomenon. Dependent variables are outcomes, or the specific phenomena you are trying to explain. No variable is inherently independent or dependent; its role depends entirely on the question you ask and the hypothesis you propose! For example, suppose your question is “Why do states that industrialize later, industrialize faster?”. The rate of state industrialization is the dependent variable. If you hypothesize that states that developed later benefited from technology transfer from earlier industrializers, then technology transfer would be your independent variable.

Q: What are the main schools of approach to comparative politics?

A: Approaches to fundamental CP questions are typically grouped into four main camps: structural (often economic), cultural, institutional, and voluntarist. For instance, your hypothesis that technology transfer drives rapid catch-up represents a structuralist approach. Conversely, your neighbor’s hypothesis—arguing that a Confucian work ethic matters more—is a cultural argument. Your roommate’s counterargument that the layout of central banks dictates development serves as an institutional argument. Finally, your friend’s claim that key figures like Bismarck and Lee Kuan Yew spurred industrialization in

Germany and Singapore respectively represents a voluntarist approach.

Q: What is a state? How is it different from a regime or government?

A: As Professor Levitsky described in the lecture, Weber defines the state as an organization with the monopoly of legitimate force over a given territory. We can think of a government as a group of people or organization that holds that monopoly whereas a regime describes the monopoly's system of rule.

Week's readings

- David Samuels, *Comparative Politics* (Pearson, 2013), pp. 4-25.
- Max Weber, *The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism* (Penguin 2002), pp. 1-36, 67-87, 105-122.
 - As Professor Levitsky noted, this is a complex reading! So focus on the main argument and don't get bogged down in the details.

Review questions

Check your understanding of this week's material and key ideas with the following questions.

1. What are the main critiques of each school of approach to comparative politics?
2. What is a hypothesis? What are the characteristics of a good hypothesis?
3. What types of cases do comparativists study? List some examples.
4. What is an institution? And how does it fit into an institutional approach?
5. How can we collect and evaluate evidence in comparative politics?
6. How does the "method of agreement" or "method of difference" help us establish causality? What are their strengths and weaknesses?

References

Samuels, David (2013). *Comparative Politics*. Pearson.